Thou shalt not bear false witness against thy neighbor.

This Commandment seems small, and yet is so great, that he who would rightly keep it must risk and imperil life and limb, goods and honor, friends and all that he has; and yet it **includes no more than the work of that small member, the tongue**, and is called ... "**telling the truth**" and, where there is need, gainsaying lies; so that **it forbids many evil works of the tongue**. **First**: those which are **committed by speaking**, and those which are **committed by keeping silent**. ... he does not do to his neighbor as he would have his neighbor do to him. This some men do for the sake of gain, some to avoid loss or shame, thereby seeking their own advantage more than God's Commandment, and excuse themselves by saying:... "the law helps him who watches"; just as if it were not as much their duty to watch for their neighbor's cause as for their own. Thus **they intentionally allow their neighbor's cause to be lost**, **although they know that it is just**. ... This sin is most frequent when the opponent is a prominent man or an enemy. For a man wants to revenge himself on his enemy: but the ill will of a man of prominence he does not wish to bring upon himself; and then begins the flattering and fawning, or, on the other hand, the withholding of the truth. **Here no one is willing to run the risk of disfavor and displeasure, loss and danger for the truth's sake; and so God's Commandment must perish**. **And this is almost universally the way of the world**. **He who would keep this Commandment, would have both hands full doing only those good works which concern the tongue**.

- How does telling the truth prevent a person from committing the sin of breaking the eighth commandment?
- How does the following verse connect telling the truth to believing in Jesus Christ? *[9] Do not lie to one another, seeing that you have put off the old self with its practices [10] and have put on the new self, which is being renewed in knowledge after the image of its creator. Colossians 3:9–10 (ESV)*

II. There is **a second bearing of witness to the truth**, which is still greater, **with which we must fight against the evil spirits**; and this concerns not temporal matters, but the Gospel and the truth of faith, which the evil spirit has at no time been able to endure, and always so manages that the great among men, whom it is hard to resist, must oppose and persecute it. Of which it is written in Psalm lxxxii, "**Rid the poor out of the hand of the wicked**, and help the forsaken to maintain his just cause."

... **if the Gospel should be stirred up and be heard again**, without doubt the whole world would be aroused and moved, and the greater portion of the kings, princes, bishops, doctors and clergy, and **all that is great, would oppose it and rage against it**, ...

Therefore, as at that time, so at all times **there are few who stand by the divine truth**, and imperil and risk life and limb, goods and honor, and all that they have, as Christ has foretold: "Ye shall be hated of all men for My Name's sake." ...

- The armor of God includes telling the truth. 14 Stand therefore, having fastened on the belt of truth, and having put on the breastplate of righteousness, Ephesians 6:14 (ESV) In your own words explain how telling the truth fights the powers of evil.
- Since we know that telling the truth is a way of fighting against the powers of evil, what would you think of telling a “white lie”, or a lie intended to spare someone’s feelings?
- If you want to spare someone’s feelings what would be better than telling a lie?

III. [**Those who will not champion the weak** and the poor] **have no faith in God**, and expect nothing good from Him. For **where such faith and confidence are**, there is also a bold, defiant, **fearless heart**, that ventures and **stands by the truth**, ... Therefore it **despises all the favor, grace, goods and honor of men**, lets them come and go as they please; as is written in Psalm xv: "**He contemneth them that contemn God, and honoreth them that fear the Lord**"; that is, the tyrants, the mighty, who persecute the truth and despise God, he does not fear, he does not regard them...

Lo, **in this Commandment** again you see briefly that **faith must be the master-workman** in this work also, so that **without it no one has courage to do this work**: so entirely are all works comprised in faith, as has now been often said. **Therefore, apart from faith all works are dead, however good the form and name they bear**. For as no one does the work of this Commandment except he be firm and fearless in the confidence of divine favor; so also he does no work of any other Commandment without the same faith: thus every one may easily by this Commandment test and weigh himself whether he be a Christian and truly believe in Christ, and thus whether he is doing good works or no. Now we see how the Almighty God has not only set our Lord Jesus Christ before us that we should believe in Him with such confidence, but also holds before us in Him an example of this same confidence and of such good works, to the end that we should believe in Him, follow Him and abide in Him forever; as He says, John xiv: "I am the Way, the Truth and the Life,"—the Way, in which we follow Him; the Truth, that we believe in Him; the Life, that we live in Him forever.

- What does courage have to do with speaking the truth?
- When did the first Christians find they need to trust in God to tell the truth –
- 7 for God gave us a spirit not of fear but of power and love and self-control. 8 Therefore do not be ashamed of the testimony about our Lord, nor of me his prisoner, but share in suffering for the gospel by the power of God, 2 Timothy 1:7–8 (ESV)
- 19 and also for me, that words may be given to me in opening my mouth boldly to proclaim the mystery of the gospel, 20 for which I am an ambassador in chains, that I may declare it boldly, as I ought to speak. Ephesians 6:19–20 (ESV)

From all this it is now manifest that all other works, **which are not commanded**, are perilous and easily known: **such as building churches**, beautifying them, **making pilgrimages**, ... has enough to do with all his powers to keep the Commandments of God, and **can never do all the good works which he is commanded to do; why then does he seek others, which are neither necessary nor commanded**, and neglect those that are necessary and commanded?

The **last two Commandments**, which **forbid evil desires of the body for pleasure and for temporal goods**, are clear in themselves; these evil desires do no harm to our neighbor, and yet they continue unto the grave, and the strife in us against them endures unto death; therefore **these two Commandments are drawn together by St. Paul into one, Romans vii, and are set as a goal unto which we do not attain, and only in our thoughts reach after until death**. For no one has ever been so holy that he felt in himself no evil inclination, especially when occasion and temptation were offered. For **original sin is born in us by nature, and temptation were offered.** For original sin is born in us by nature, and may be checked, but not entirely uprooted, except through the death of the body; which for this reason is profitable and a thing to be desired. To this may God help us. Amen.

- At the time Luther wrote this he followed the numbering of the ten commandments according the the method used by Catholics today. They consider coveting a neighbor's wife, to be commandment number nine, and coveting a neighbor's property, to be commandment number 10. Today, Protestants count them as one commandment. Catholics and Lutherans also number the first four commandments differently. Protestants consider "You shall have no other gods before me" and "You shall not make for yourself a graven image" to be two commandments, where the Catholics consider them to be one commandment.
- Why does wanting what belongs to someone else show a lack of faith in God? 15 And he said to them, "Take care, and be on your guard against all covetousness, for one's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions." Luke 12:15 (ESV)